

Presentation skills

THE BEST PUBLIC SPEAKERS ARE CLEAR AND ENGAGING.

Even a well-written speech will be dull if it is badly presented. It's important to speak clearly and to engage an audience with the right tone of voice, body language, and even props.

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Flash cards

It's tempting to read out a speech word by word, but a spontaneous delivery is more entertaining for an audience. It's best to learn as much of a speech as possible, and prepare small cards with the important points, quotations, and statistics to use as prompts.

Write the important points on a flash card. These can be written in note form.

Why I love Brussels sprouts

- I have a secret. I love Brussels sprouts!
- The day I changed my mind.
- They have a bad reputation but don't deserve it.
- Largest producer is the Netherlands, with 82,000 tons a year.

Include statistics because they are easy to forget.

Speak up

A speaker should never shout, but should project his or her voice so that it can be heard around the room. It's also important not to speak too quickly, as the audience may find it difficult to keep up. In fact, pausing occasionally can be very effective because it gives an audience time to think about what is being said. Finally, there is no need to hide an accent, but the pronunciation should be clear.

Some nutritional facts about Brussels sprouts

- Brussels sprouts contain more vitamin C than oranges. (pause)
- There is almost no fat in Brussels sprouts. (pause)
- Unlike most vegetables, Brussels sprouts are high in protein. (pause)

Include pauses on a flash card to show when to break for a few seconds.

Intonation

When people talk, their voices go up and down and get louder and quieter. This natural variation is called intonation. If a person's voice stays the same, it will sound robotic and put the audience to sleep. Stressing important words or phrases helps to create a good rhythm, and will emphasize those points.

Underline or highlight important words or phrases that need to be stressed.

History of Brussels sprouts

- Forerunners to the Brussels sprout were cultivated in Ancient Rome.
- American Founding Father Thomas Jefferson grew Brussels sprouts.
- Today, production is huge. Approximately 32,000 tons are produced in the United States every year.